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DISABILITY AND SOCIAL MEDIA

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> Social media is social. It is important for us all and it should be open to all. . . . It is not necessarily about living a life on the Internet. It is about bypassing distance in the real world, making new friends, and participating in all the conversations between our family members and the communities we live in. . . . Social media can break down barriers and change lives. For example, a hearing impaired child can now share stories with their friends via Skype, and a vision impaired user can read about his brother's trip to the Far East via a blog site. . . . Social media is truly social. It connects the dots. (Cahill & Hollier, 2009)

Introduction

Media have long been social. The social nature, functions, and implications of media are something that have been widely debated, especially with the new kinds of convergent, digital media centering on the internet that have emerged since the early 1990s. As discussed in this book, the term social media is now widely used to indicate particular qualities of digital media. Central to social media are social networks; interactivity; the role of users in generating media content; participatory cultures; sharing; reliance on personal information; locational technologies, mapping and navigation; mobile media; and new kinds of closed versus open platforms. The implication of social media in the reshaping of media cultures, social relations, and everyday life is something that is being avidly researched and debated. As yet, there is little work on disability and social media—a fascinating and important topic. Critical theories over the past two decades have contributed much to our understanding that disability is as much a social phenomenon as it is a bodily, material, economic, technological, spiritual,

and philosophical matter. Disability, then, has much to tell us about what the *social* in social media means.

For people with disabilities, social media is seen as a "social lifeline" (Morrison, 2010). Take the case of Edsel Odom. Edsel has a disability and is an avid user of social media. His favorite platform is Myspace because "you really get a chance to know people [on Myspace] as opposed to the glimpse you get from looking at Facebook" (Morrison, 2010). Eclipsed in recent years by Facebook and many other social networking applications, Myspace was the most popular social networking site in the United States between 2006 and 2008 (Ostrow, 2009) and was widely used elsewhere. What is interesting about Myspace is that members design their own page to reflect their interests and personalities. As a result, Myspace pages tend to be cluttered and often do not follow accessibility guidelines. The hundreds of links that can appear on a page make navigation with a screen reader problematic (Cahill & Hollier, 2009). In the case of Odom, while Myspace is compatible with the adaptive technology he uses, many other users with disabilities, particularly those with vision impairments, experience accessibility problems:

> Users of MySpace are encouraged to "pimp their page" by adding features unique to their identity. For example users select music to automatically load when other people navigate to their page. Automatic loading of audio disrupts screen readers when they attempt to navigate a page and breaks one of the simplest rules of creating an accessible page. While users are creating the inaccessibility, MySpace has a responsibility in establishing tool kits because the skill required to "pimp" a page is minimal. (Ellis & Kent, 2011)

Although the opportunity for unstructured user-generated content on Myspace alleviates the social isolation experienced by many people with disabilities, it also illustrates an inherent problem of access regarding social media participation for people with other disabilities. Myspace has been aware of their accessibility issues since at least 2006, when the American Federation for the Blind first alerted them. In 2010 Myspace continued to be inaccessible (Cahill & Hollier, 2009). While there are various reasons for Myspace's declining popularity, its failure to address accessibility issues and embrace users with disabilities certainly plays a part (Ellis & Kent, 2011).

In recent years the dominance Facebook and Myspace have exhibited over social media has been challenged by the micro-blogging site Twitter. Users of Twitter communicate tweets using 140 characters or less. Barbara, profiled on BBC disability blog *Ouch!,* believes Twitter is popular amongst people with disabilities, and vision impairment in particular, because it is text based:

> Twitter does away with the eye-contact element of a conversation. We're all equal and I think that's why people like it so much. (Tracey, 2011)

She accesses it using Qwitter for PC, Tweets60 for smart phones running the Symbian series 60 operating system, and Tweetlist for iPhone, which she describes as accessible. However, Twitter does not have an explicit accessibility policy. Unlike Myspace, Twitter is largely text based and does not rely on video or images. Nor are users encouraged to "pimp" their pages; in fact, the text size cannot be changed. The site is also heavily reliant on the use of a mouse. Although Twitter has a reputation of being simple to use, this is not the case for a significant number of users. This is a problem that cuts across the understood dynamics of social media: namely, that social media is valued for encouraging innovation and collaboration and so is felt to get better as more people use it more often.

A third vignette is the case of Apple's iPhone, the acclaimed technology that has galvanized the smartphone market. Many users with disabilities have adopted the iPhone with alacrity, quite a number praising its accessibility features. One prominent such user is famous singer Stevie Wonder, who in the middle of a concert in a Los Angeles nightclub in September 2011 praised Steve Jobs and Apple for making the iPhone accessible, saying: "There is nothing that you can do on the iPhone or iPad that I can't do" (The Next Web, 2011). The iPhone and other smartphones (such as those operating on Google's Android operating system) have instigated the "apps culture," a new force in mobile social media. However, the iPhone did not have accessibility features when first launched in mid-2007. It took until mid-2009 for Apple to make available on its iPhone (and then iPad) the VoiceOver accessible features for users with vision and mobility impairments, similar to those available on its operating system on its computers. For this reason, New Zealand–based Blind technology expert and blogger Jonathon Mosen (2009) has been alternately frustrated and impressed by Apple's much vaunted iPhone:

> Apple should be congratulated for taking a device that clearly breached Section 255 of the US Telecommunications Act [regarding accessibility] and having a go and making it compliant. . . . Whether it can compete with well established offerings in terms of productive, efficient access, I am not convinced. . . . Are arrow keys and a keyboard or number pad really so bad? It would appear to me to be an optimal interface for a blind person to use.

For its part, Google has been steadily rendering its Android phones accessible. Amazon.com has also finally been tackling the accessibility issues with its Kindle devices. Despite this, there remain accessibility problems with smartphones, e-readers, and tablet computers compared to the existing accessibility features on preexisting second- and third-generation mobile phones.

These three brief case studies illustrate the central issues in disability across leading social media—whether social networking systems (Myspace, Facebook, and a multitude of other applications around the world); micro-blogging (Twitter and many other applications, especially in emerging markets such as China); internet-based video and audio sharing sites such as YouTube; immersive worlds

(such as Second Life); or mobile media (smartphones, tablets, locative media, and other media). Yet inaccessible design remains a central and constant problem across many social media platforms, including those designed exclusively for use by people with disabilities (AbilityNet, 2008; Ellis & Kent, 2011). This prevents many people with disabilities from participating in social media. This has serious implications not just for how people with disabilities figure in contemporary digital media, but for their wider participation in culture and society.

A further difficulty is that where disabled users of digital technology do surface in cultures of social media, their public discussion, and analysis, tends mostly still to be in uncritical celebration of how social media magically overcome discrimination and social rejection. However, this is only one part of the picture, as many with disability are prevented from initial and continuing access while some become effectively disabled by the online environment. For example, in many social media, people with mobility impairment will no longer need to disclose their disability, while people with dyslexia, who in traditional face-to-face interaction would have an invisible disability, find themselves "outed" by the affordances and norms of many applications and emergent online social norms. Significantly, inaccessible interfaces may prevent people with vision impairments from participating at all. In this light, we offer an overview and analysis of social media and disability, highlighting the two contradictory but linked aspects that characterize it.

Despite such inaccessibility, we can still point to a great deal of innovation amongst users with disabilities, their advocates, and those interacting with them on sites including Facebook, Twitter, YouTube, and Second Life—as our vignettes reveal. Disabled people form a sizable proportion of users of social media. Many people with disabilities have taken avidly to the full range of social media. Their use and consumption of (and, quite often, innovations with) social media are not well recognized—compared to other uses and users of social media. Thus, the innovative uses of the technology and cultures of social media by people with disabilities not only form an important part of the overall picture—such uses offer important insights into the nature of social media themselves.

Against this backdrop, our first aim in this chapter is to bring to readers' attention the important variety of uses of social media by people with disability. Secondly, when it does surface, use of social media by people with disabilities is still too often talked about in ways that stereotype, discriminate, and "disable." So our second aim is to describe, analyze, and critique the ways of talking about ("discourses") disability in social media. This leads us to our third aim in this chapter: to highlight accessibility issues. The way people with disabilities are talked about—and imagined—as using social media are often out of kilter, as we have suggested, with their actual uses. This is a problem related to how disability exists and is created in society. These power relations of disability shape technology too. So here we identify and discuss the very serious problems with inaccessibility of social media technology, which forms barriers to participation

in social media by people with disabilities (and indeed many other people as well) (Craven, 2008).

The Paradox of Disability and Social Media

Before we proceed, it is important to understand a little about contemporary approaches to disability. Many view disability as an undesirable tragedy that should be cured. An alternative approach called the "social media" sees disability as located in social structures and inaccessible environments (Barnes & Mercer, 2004). Other approaches have followed that explore the cultural, political, economic, psychological, and bodily dimensions of how disability is shaped and how we can understand its distinctive power relations (Campbell, 2009; Sieber, 2008). Despite these new ideas, popular definitions of disability are still often premised on a discourse of deficit. That is, disability is a problem that particular individuals have, which makes them less able to cope with society or, worse still, inferior or less than human. Whereas, the impairments that definitions of disability revolve around can instead be seen as an integral part of being human and mortal (Goggin & Newell, 2005; Shakespeare, 2006). This model of disability is based on principles of empowerment and argues that able-bodied mainstream society disables people that have impairments through an inaccessibly built environment and the perpetuation of stereotypes and prejudicial attitudes. For example, digital media creates disability when its designers build inaccessibility into their interfaces, devices, programs, and assumptions. Thus people are "disabled" by such technological environments. Despite work into creating enabling environments, the examples with which we begin this chapter underscore the fact that some aspects of social media—such as the increasing use of graphics and user-generated content and a rejection of web standards—are having a detrimental effect on the inclusion of people with disability (Craven, 2008). As the importance of social media proliferates in all our lives, the potential cost of being excluded escalates.

Thus the new critical approaches to disability (Goodley, 2010; Pothier & Devlin, 2005) emphasize the importance of acknowledging, analyzing, and debating the ways in which new technologies—such as social media—shape disability and its relations (Ellis & Kent, 2011; Goggin & Newell, 2003). An obvious, yet unrealized, implication of this is that it is vitally important to create accessible environments—especially in online, mobile, social media. The increasing use of social media and other digital technologies is advancing this model, as adaptive technologies can be used to enable a fuller participation of people with disability—and there are many excellent examples of this occurring (Soderstrom, 2009). Moreover, the advent of the internet has coincided with a greater awareness of disability and accessible environments (Craven, 2008).

Having briefly established the key dimensions of disability, let us now turn to the antecedents of today's social media. In 1997, Sir Tim Berners-Lee (1997),

inventor of the World Wide Web and director of the World Wide Web Consortium, described his vision for the web:

> The dream . . . is of a common information space in which we communicate by sharing information. . . . Once the state of our interactions was online, we could then use computers to help us analyze it, make sense of what we are doing, where we individually fit in, and how we can better work together.

As we can see, the kinds of social communication, interaction, and networking that characterize social media go further back into the histories of the internet than merely emerging with the notion of Web 2.0. What is significant about Berners-Lee's (1997) vision, and the origins of the web, is that he presciently foregrounded the inclusion of people with disabilities:

> As we move towards a highly connected world, it is critical that the Web be useable by anyone, regardless of individual capabilities and disabilities. . . . The W3C is committed to removing accessibility barriers for all people with disabilities—including the deaf, blind, physically challenged, and cognitively or visually impaired.

Of course, Berners-Lee's vision has distinct shortcomings and thus has received significant criticism. For instance, video bloggers have raised questions about Berners-Lee's accessible web ideas, suggesting that they do not give sufficient consideration to the importance of interactive video communication (Out-Law News, 2006). Despite these weaknesses, access to the internet for everyone regardless of disability was essential for Berners-Lee relatively early in the inception of the web—as it has been more recently in his efforts to inaugurate a truly accessible mobile Web 2.0.

Despite accessibility problems, people with disabilities have used the internet very widely indeed. We have already alluded to the importance of online technologies for social and cultural participation. A central reason why the internet has been important for people with disabilities is something shared by many other groups: namely, the internet provides new opportunities for communication, information, and media. Consider, for instance, the long-standing problem with how people with disabilities are represented in the media. While social attitudes are changing and media representations becoming more diverse, disability is typically represented in very stereotypical ways. The internet has provided a multitude of ways in which people with disabilities and disability media organizations and advocates can broadcast themselves (to borrow the famous YouTube motto)—and in so doing offer a wide range of representations of disability. E-mail was an early way that Blind people, for instance, were able to distribute information—using mail lists not only as a form of communication with people around the world,

but also as a form of alternative media to mainstream media and even well-established minority options (the long-standing Radio for the Print Handicapped, for instance). Web pages, especially with accessibility measures, were a way that individual users wishing to share information, news, and views about disability could do so relatively easily. Alejandro Martínez-Cabrera (2010) describes the web as life changing for people with disabilities, allowing them a greater range of inclusion:

> The Internet has brought enormous benefits to people with disabilities, allowing them to become more competitive when applying for jobs, lessen their dependence on others, engage more actively in public debates and connect with their peers in ways that were impossible before.

With the advent of blogs, disability culture on the internet developed in fertile ways (Kuusisto, 2007). For many disabled users, blogs offered a platform for distributing news, critique, and commentary, as well as personal stories and information. Notable innovations included widespread use of audio blogs by Blind users (building on internet radio and podcasting) and video blogs by Deaf users (as, especially with broadband networks, video supports the visual medium of sign language). These cultures of use of the internet by people with disabilities prefigure—and overlap with—what we regard as the full-blown platforms of social media.

As our case studies suggest, there are many ways in which people with disabilities are using social media—most of these remaining relatively uncharted and unresearched. YouTube has offered a new platform for people with disabilities to produce their own content about their lives, perspectives, and narratives—and circulate it to others. Whereas, previously, video, film, and televisual content and programming representing disability in non-stereotypical ways was difficult to find, YouTube has made available a wide selection of amateur, professional, and, of course, "pro-am" accounts of disability, mixing the everyday, banal representation of disability (the quotidian, quirky, and tedious being YouTube's strong suit) with documentaries, entertainment, and other kinds of video. To take but one example, Marty Sheedy, in April 2007, uploaded a three-minute video to YouTube, entitled "Living and Overcoming Life with a Disability," aiming to explain "what it's like to be me"—which four years later had approximately fifty thousand views (Sheedy, 2007). Sheedy's video also attracted a wide range of comment, ranging from enthusiastic support and identification, to cruel jokes and abuse. As with many other social media, highlighted in hate sites and offensive humor groups on Facebook widely covered by other media, we find discrimination, violence, and disavowal of people with disabilities openly brandished (as it still exists in everyday life), whereas in other media such attitudes now require censorship, euphemism, sublimation, or use of code words to convey the same point. There has been little discussion of this continuing, oppressive discursive construction of disability in social media, or indeed other digital technologies; however, we can look to the

important work on race on, and after, the internet as a very suggestive example, with striking parallels and echoes (Nakamura & Chow-White, 2012).

Immersive worlds have had a long history, dating back to the text-based MUDs and MOOs of the relatively early internet (Goggin & Newell, 2003). Disabled users, and disability, have also long figured in such online communities and now have received considerable attention and debate, especially with Second Life (Hickey-Moody & Wood, 2008). While a distinctive media form in its own right, Second Life is now closely bound up with the alliance of different kinds of media under the social media banner. Within the context of their use by people with disability, virtual worlds are often celebrated for their potential to allow people with disability an opportunity to "pass" as nondisabled. However, for some people, disability is an identity that cannot be left behind. Take for example Simon Stevens (aka Simon Walsh) who founded the Wheelies nightclub for people with disabilities in *Second Life*. Stevens suggests we all have impairments and describes Wheelies as inclusive (Hickey-Moody & Wood, 2009). Initially unable to find a wheelchair for his avatar, Stevens began creating his own (fig. 9.1, fig. 9.2). Thus he was the first to use a wheelchair full time in Second Life. As Stevens shows, virtual worlds such as Second Life offer unlimited potential for participation, social



FIGURE 9.1



FIGURE 9.2

engagement, and political activism. When everything about the construction of an avatar is mediated and usually highly stylized, people with disability can choose whether or not to reveal their impairment.

Social networking systems have become very important to users with disabilities, especially as these applications now predominate among populations around the world. In the Anglophone world, much attention has been paid to the salience of Facebook, with which disability communities and disabled users have experimented widely. Such applications and user cultures build on the histories of online communities important to early disability internet use, such as bulletin boards. Glenda Watson Hyatt (aka the Left Thumb Blogger), accessibility expert and person with a disability, describes the importance of accessible social media to people with disabilities:

> For someone who has always struggled to communicate verbally and who has often felt isolated and alone when in group gatherings, social networking has opened a world to me. (Glenda Watson Hyatt, in Ellis & Kent, 2011, p. 15)

Social media facilitates the creation of communities as people can quickly and easily mobilize online around a common interest. Facebook provided the

opportunity for people with disabilities to form a community and through feedback provide more people with disabilities the opportunity to participate on Facebook. Thus many users with disabilities and many advocates also see social media as bringing great changes for people with disabilities. For instance, Australian Human Rights Commissioner Graeme Innes (2009) describes social networking, when made accessible, as opening a new world for people with disabilities. This is also the view of leading media and disability scholar Beth Haller, whose blog, website, and Twitter feed have been significant in charting the migration of, and take-up by, users with disabilities of social media. We would note here that while there is some discussion of disability users and Facebook, there is little discussion—in English language at least—of how users with disability are taking to the multitude of other social networking systems around the world, especially in the Asia-Pacific region, in countries such as Korea, Japan, and China (AbilityNet, 2008; Berners-Lee, 1997; Ellis & Kent, 2011; Goggin & Newell, 2003; Foley & Voithofer, 2008).

Disability Innovations and Challenges in Social Media

From this discussion of the many uses and innovations in social media by people with disabilities, let us now return to the vexed issue of accessibility. An interesting contrast can be drawn between disability and accessibility in the first decade of the web and the situation obtaining currently with social media. Take, for example, the respective visions of Berners-Lee and Mark Zuckerberg, founder of Facebook. In many ways, Zuckerberg's descriptions of his motivations for creating the social networking site Facebook resonate with that of Berners-Lee (and, further back, to other pre-web internet pioneers):

> People being able to share the information they wanted and having access to the information they wanted is just a better world: People can connect better with the people around them, understand more of what's going on with the people around them, and understand more in general. Also, openness fundamentally affects a lot of the core institutions in society—the media, the economy, how people relate to the government and just their leadership. We thought that stuff was really interesting to pursue. (Quoted in Vogelstein, 2009)

Zuckerberg too speaks of creating social connections online, but where Berners-Lee saw the inclusion of people with disabilities as vital, Zuckerberg did not—and, to our knowledge, has not done so elsewhere. This is a crucial difference that goes to the heart of disability and social media. Unless the expectations, habits, and uses of people with disabilities are explicitly acknowledged and explored, and accessible design ardently pursued, much of the social media landscape can be disabling. Thus critiques of disability and accessibility form a significant additional agenda to add to current work highlighting the problems

with social media as open platforms. Many important, if not ubiquitous, social media are owned by entrepreneurs, by commercial interests, and, increasingly, by the very large horizontally and vertically integrated corporations that dominate communications and media (Castells, 2009; Goggin, 2011). As yet, however, few of those many researchers and commentators drawing attention to the enclosure of digital media incorporate disability and accessibility in their accounts. Yet the same forces and patterns that are shaping social networking systems, such as Facebook, for instance, to deal in a preemptive way with user data and information also are likely involved in the reluctance to take accessibility seriously.

Much discourse on disability and social media, of which mainstream media coverage is a useful index, is underpinned by a long-standing assumption (or myth) that technology brings salvation for people with disability—allowing us to transcend the limitations of our impairments. Here the way that social media and disability is represented has strong echoes in how such technology is presented in general (Goggin & Newell, 2003). Social media is either something magical and transformative, or it is an evil and contributes to a dystopian society. The reality, of course, is that social media has been involved in very significant transformations for people with disabilities. However, in doing so, social media does not "end" or "transcend" disability. Further, the threshold issue for so many people with disabilities when it comes to social media remains accessibility.

As we have noted, Tim Berners-Lee (1997) envisioned the World Wide Web as a common information space where people could benefit from collaboration. Ease of access was vital to his vision, and he argued that "access regardless of disability" was particularly important. The well-known work of the World Wide Web Consortium Web Accessibility Initiative (W3C WAI) has sought to put these into practice, providing technical standards and guidance for accessible websites followed by many governments, businesses, organizations, and users around the world—with mixed results (Asakawa, 2005; Ellcessor, 2010). The Web Accessibility Initiative is perhaps the best known of a welter of accessibility initiatives undertaken by various disability and technology specialist organizations around the world. Such organizations often work with social media and other technology companies and organizations, implementing social and online media to encourage and pursue accessible technology. What is clear is that digital information can potentially be accessed in many different formats (such as text, image, sound, multimedia) using a range of adaptive technology (whether screen readers, Braille outputs, or keyboard and/or mouse).

The importance of the Web Accessibility Initiative was bound up with the public internet—a commonly available platform that would also be accessible for people with disabilities. As the internet has developed—especially via the complex, interdependent technological systems that social media represents—it has proven difficult to implement such a vision. And there has been surprisingly little commitment to making accessibility a "natural" feature of social media by the multitude of specific software, hardware, and network providers and other

technology companies that make up the social media landscape. This is evident in the case of social networking systems, notably Facebook.

As we have mentioned, the accessibility of social networking sites and the implications this has for the exclusion of people with disabilities has been of concern for some time. In 2008, UK charity AbilityNet (2008) noted:

> Social networking websites are an increasingly important part of the internet and have become vitally important both for work and leisure activities. For many disabled people, social networking websites offer huge opportunities to conduct business and to socialise without physical barriers.

However, AbilityNet was critical of accessibility across social media. Their analysis covered Myspace, Facebook, YouTube, Yahoo!, and Bebo and found five accessibility and usability issues common to the five sites: no help section or accessibility page for people with disabilities; sites were impossible to access using keyboard only; graphics lacked alternative text; use of CAPTCHA (a text-based method of authenticating user identification); and little support for or encouragement for including captions in online videos, with only Yahoo! providing an option to do so.

These issues combine to make navigation of the social networking sites using assistive technology difficult or impossible. Valuable opportunities for social networking are prevented by an inaccessible interface (AbilityNet, 2008). Foley and Voithofer (2008) target the disabling use of CAPTCHA at the login stage of Facebook as proof that exclusion is built into social technologies in such a way that reflects certain discourses of power. By design, the visual verification system of CAPTCHA requires "human" and not machine translation. This reflects an assumption that all humans can see or—in the case of audio CAPTCHA—hear, and it can block those using adaptive technologies such as a screen reader (Ellis & Kent, 2011). CAPTCHA is a concrete example of the way technology is designed to limit our use with it and exclude people with disability. Unfortunately, since 2007 there has been limited progress with accessibility in social networking systems. In 2009 the Australian disability technology organization Media Access Australia analyzed Skype, Facebook, YouTube, Flickr, Twitter, and Myspace and significantly found Facebook to be a good choice for people with disabilities, although issues with CAPTCHA remained (Cahill & Hollier, 2009). This was because Facebook overhauled its site in consultation with the America Foundation for the Blind in 2008. Key to this achievement was the political mobilization of groups of people with disabilities, fittingly via Facebook.

The decision to make a social networking site inaccessible is inherently political, not least because there are many more different options available digitally than there usually are in the offline world. In suggesting that inaccessibility of social media implies a politics is to take away from the complexity of both technology design and implementation, on the one hand, and the reconfiguration of the social relations of disability currently underway, on the other hand. Take, for instance, the

range of social media applications used by a typical user. This would likely include Facebook (or another social networking system, such as LinkedIn); Twitter (available via many different forms, including mobile apps); YouTube; photo-sharing sites (such as Flickr); locative media (such as Foursquare and Facebook Places); navigation, maps, and way-finding software (such as Google Maps and Google Earth); web browsers; social bookmarking; Second Life or other immersive worlds; and blogs. Add to this, for many disabled users, particular adaptive or favored interfaces such as screen readers. The obvious issue is that making social media accessible requires each of these particular applications to take seriously accessible design, and for each to work together with each other—upping the ante with compatibility and interoperability issues among social media applications with which technology developers and investors are already struggling (Annable, Goggin, & Stienstra, 2007).

Yet despite the obvious difficulties posed by accessible design, there are also real commercial benefits to be gained. Accessible design ensures that technology is available to a greater range of users—those who are not disabled (or do not identify with a disability), as well as people with disability. There exist many business, government, social, and citizenship benefits for accessibility. These possibilities underscore the importance of ensuring that social media technologies do not remain inaccessible, thus following a trajectory by which they perpetuate ableist assumptions of normativity (Goggin & Newell, 2003). Given the expanding possibilities of technology for opening up accessibility, there remains little rationale for building in inaccessibility—unnecessary limitations of technology that reflect a disabling world view (Foley & Voithofer, 2008).

By definition, social media refers to platforms that encourage input from its community of users. This dynamic feedback blurs the line between media and audience and provides the opportunity for improvement in the site's functioning. People with disabilities have been integral in improving Facebook's accessibility for people with disabilities and usability for the entire community. Shortly after Facebook was launched, the Facebook group The Official Petition for a More Accessible Facebook was created by a student with a vision impairment in order to highlight issues of access experienced by people with vision impairment and learning disabilities. The group quickly attracted the attention of Facebook administration, who eventually improved the site in consultation with The American Association for the Blind the following year.

Skeptical approaches to digital technology and disability recognize that as we develop technology we can choose to enable or disable users, and that superficial approaches to universal design and disability can again reproduce narrowly defined notions of normality. As Goggin and Newell (2003) recognize, accessibility for a person with a certain type of impairment can have disastrous consequences for a person with a different impairment:

> There is no doubt that [universal design] offers a great deal in reorienting thinking and design to factor in a variety of functional needs. Yet a

> challenge for universal design is found in the very diversity of situations and human circumstances. (Goggin & Newell, 2003, p. 149)

The implications of this is the need for incorporation of difference into cultural and policy formations and consultation of disability groups in the design phase of digital technologies. The result, they argue, will be the inclusion of not just people with disability but all people who exist on the margins. (It is worth noting that Goggin and Newell are wary of the discourse of "inclusion" throughout digital disability, believing it can sometimes function as an excuse to perpetuate disablism.) Ellis and Kent (2011) extend Goggin and Newell's digital disability argument in *Disability and New Media* in light of both user-generated content and the possibility for user-generated output and accessibility 2.0, which accompanies social media. Accessibility 2.0 is a user-centric approach that assumes technological innovation and that users will access the same information in different ways. Such openness and ease of access is vital to the success of social media.

Conclusion and Future Avenues for Research

Social media continue their rise in media, culture, and society. As other contributions to this *Handbook* illustrate, social media offer extraordinary opportunities for new ways to communicate, gain information, tell stories, offer cultural expressions and representation, conduct business, do politics, and, above all, connect and participate. Social media also heighten existing problems and debates about the role of media—and lead to the formulation of new problems. In this chapter, we have sought to provide an overview and analysis of the important area of disability in social media. What we have highlighted are the great variety and innovation in uses of social media by people with disabilities and the kinds of issues and conversations that are underway regarding this—and that perhaps should be fostered. Approaching disability in this way remains an unfamiliar approach for students, teachers, and researchers of media—as indeed it does for policymakers and publics.

A much more familiar way of framing disability and new media, which we now see in relation to social media, is accessibility. When disability is discussed at an academic conference or public event about social media, it is more often than not about accessibility. Accessibility is extremely important, and we too have continually drawn attention to it as an issue in this chapter. As we have sought to illustrate, social media platforms are characterized by networks that get stronger the more people are in and contributing to them. Excluding an entire group of people makes little sense when success is achieved through collaboration with as many people as possible. So accessibility is unfinished business—indeed business that many technology companies, organizations, and institutions have not yet even begun to embark upon. However, there are many reasons now for grasping the nettle of accessibility and design—from international and national legal compliance, through economic, social, and cultural benefits, to the imperatives of

ethics and justice. Accessibility is actually no simple matter. So some of the most promising approaches to accessibility seek to open it up as a concept and set of practices, something in which the vibrant experimentation, emerging practices, and research concerning social media can play an important part. Work on disability and accessible technology in the humanities and social sciences is relatively recent; however, there is important research emerging that seeks to understand the social and cultural underpinnings of digital technology, including social media—yet there remains much to do.

There are some obvious directions for future work, then, in disability and social media. Firstly, we need to know much more about how people with disabilities are actually using social media. Other than discussions (including those using social media) by individuals and groups of people with disabilities and work by disability technology specialist organizations, there is almost no scholarly research into disability and social media. Actually there is little critical research on disability and the internet, disability and mobile media, and disability and media either. While there now exists recognition of the importance of disability in communication, culture, and media studies, there is very little work. So we lack baseline statistics and demographic information on how many people with disabilities are using social media, which applications they use, how often, where, why, and for what purposes: the fundamental data of any communications and media research. Building on this, we have very few qualitative studies of any sort—whether sociological, critical, or cultural or using interdisciplinary methods and frameworks, such as those in disability studies or internet studies—of different communities, groups, audiences, or publics of social media users with disabilities. We have even less—we can safely say "no"—international comparative studies of the cultures of use of social media by people with disabilities across different cultural, linguistic, economic, gender, or national settings.

Secondly, a central problem for research and practice is understanding why designing, framing, and implementing technology for people with disabilities—including the achievement of accessibility—proves so difficult to bring about. The stakes in these struggles over accessibility and social media have been heightened with the advent of the 2008 United Nations Convention on the Rights of Persons with Disability, which, if fully implemented, include many provisions dealing with the importance of accessibility of digital technology as a human right.

Recommending Readings

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